Key points: South Korea and Japan cyberattacks (Reuters, October 9, 2026)

1. What happened?

- **South Korea:** Nine banks and two mega-churches are investigating cyberattacks that may have involved AI tools.
- **Japan:** Companies including Daiwa Securities, SoftBank, and Lawson experienced a surge in cyber incidents.
- Authorities are still investigating the extent to which AI was used in the attacks.

2. Important statistics

Japan	South Korea
86 incidents	**1,236 incidents**
Recorded in September 2026	Reported in the first half of 2026
+20%	**+76.8%**
South Korean incidents year over year	Increase in reported ransomware incidents

Source: Figures reported in the supplied Reuters article. Japan's 86 incidents were approximately 18% higher than August and 37% higher than July.

3. How AI is helping cybercriminals

- **Automated vulnerability scanning:** AI can help identify weaknesses in software and systems more quickly.
- **AI-generated phishing:** Attackers can create convincing emails and messages in different languages.
- **Lower technical barriers:** People with limited hacking skills can use AI to assist with complex tasks.
- **Faster attacks:** AI can automate repetitive activities, reducing the time and effort required.
- **Harder detection:** AI-assisted attacks may produce more varied and convincing activity, making detection more challenging.

4. Main attack types mentioned

Attack type	Meaning
Hacking	Gaining unauthorized access to systems
DDoS	Overwhelming a service with traffic

Ransomware	Encrypting or stealing data to demand payment
Phishing	Tricking people into revealing credentials or sensitive information
Smishing	Using fraudulent SMS messages to steal information

5. What was the suspected attacker's role?

According to CrowdStrike's assessment cited by Reuters, a suspected 26-year-old attacker based in China used a Chinese-developed AI agent and Anthropic's Claude Code in the campaign against South Korean banks. Investigators believe AI assistance was significant, but the investigation was ongoing.

Important: This is an attributed security assessment, not proof that AI was used in every reported incident or that all attacks were conducted by the same person.

6. How can organizations defend themselves?

1. **MFA:** Enable multi-factor authentication to protect accounts.
2. **Patch management:** Update software and fix known vulnerabilities promptly.
3. **Security monitoring:** Use SIEM tools such as Splunk to detect suspicious activity.
4. **Penetration testing:** Test systems with authorization to identify security weaknesses.
5. **Phishing awareness:** Train employees to recognize malicious emails and messages.
6. **Incident response:** Maintain tested backups and procedures to contain attacks quickly.
7. **Regular security assessments:** Financial institutions should review access controls and test their defences regularly.

Interview-ready conclusion

“The Reuters report of October 9, 2026, highlights how AI is lowering the technical barrier for cybercriminals. South Korean banks and Japanese companies are facing an increase in cyber incidents, including concerns involving ransomware and DDoS attacks. AI can help attackers automate vulnerability discovery and create convincing phishing campaigns. Organizations should strengthen MFA, patch management, SIEM monitoring, and incident response. As a cybersecurity professional, I believe defenders must use automation and AI responsibly to detect threats faster and protect sensitive data.”